

CV Building Guide for College Placements

Table of Contents

1. Basic Formatting and Styling
2. Content Writing Guidelines
3. ATS Compatibility and Technical Tips
4. ERP System Specific Tips
5. Project and Achievement Presentation
6. Common Mistakes to Avoid
7. Interview Preparation
8. Pre-Review Checklist
9. Dress Code for Interviews

Basic Formatting and Styling

Typography and Font Guidelines

- **Font size:** Strictly use 10 or 11 pt font. Never use 9 pt or below as it's difficult for recruiters to read, especially when printed
- **Bold text:** Use font size 1 smaller than regular text for bold portions
- **Spacing:** Use only 1 space, never 2-3 spaces in a single place
- **No full stops:** Don't use full stops with bullet points
- **Bullet spacing:** Always put spaces after bullets

Symbol and Punctuation Rules

- **Commas:** Space after commas, not before
- **Colons:** Space after colons, not before

- **Hyphens:**
 - Space before and after hyphens in ranges (e.g., Apr 2021 - Jul 2021)
 - No spaces around hyphens in hyphenated words
- **Slashes:** No spaces around forward slashes
- **Brackets:** No space after opening bracket or before closing bracket (applies to parentheses, square brackets, curly braces)
- **Pipe characters:** Space before and after pipe characters

Date Formatting

- **Format:** Use "Apr 2021 - Jul 2021" format
- **Full years:** Mention years in full (2022, not '22) as much as possible
- **Present tense:** Keep 'P' in CAPS when writing "Present"
- **Quote character:** Optionally use quote character like "Jan' 2021"
- **Alignment:** Align dates to the extreme right of the page
- **ATS compatibility:** Use MM/YYYY format for ATS systems (especially for off-campus applications)

Line and Content Management

- **Line filling:** Try to fill 70% of the whitespace available on each line (or at least 75%)
- **Single line points:** Keep all points within a single line when possible
- **Point splitting:** Split one point into multiple if needed to maintain line filling
- **One-page rule:** Highly advisable to keep resume to 1 page
- **Consistent formatting:** Maintain very consistent formatting throughout

Content Writing Guidelines

Action Words and Sentence Structure

- **Start with action words:** Begin each point with an impactful action word
- **Avoid repetition:** Use different action words to avoid monotony
- **Power verbs:** Use powerful action verbs (refer to [The Muse guide](#))
- **Harvard guide:** Refer to [HBS LinkedIn guide](#)
- **Impactful positioning:** Place most important things in the first half of the CV

STAR Model Implementation

Follow the STAR model for better storytelling:

- **Situation:** The situation at hand
- **Tasks:** Tasks to be done
- **Actions:** Actions that you take
- **Results:** Results which your actions bring

Numbers and Data Integration

- **Quantify everything:** Put as many numbers/figures/data as possible
- **Replace adjectives:** Replace adjectives with concrete numbers
- **Show impact:** Highlight the impact of your work/contribution
- **Examples of metrics:**
 - Model performance improvement
 - Budget managed
 - Revenue generated/saved
 - Code size reduced
 - Time efficiency improvement
 - Latency reduction
 - Operation optimization
 - Position/rank achievements
 - Comparative performance metrics
- **Example:** "Increased the accuracy of the model by 150% from 0.3 to 0.75"

Content Focus and Individualization

- **Personal focus:** Keep CV specific to you alone
 - **Minimize organization details:** Speak less about org/society/competition/summit details
 - **Add individuality:** Make organizational mentions relevant to your personal contribution
 - **One point per bullet:** Each CV point should convey only one idea
 - **Confident content:** Include only points you feel confident explaining
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ATS Compatibility and Technical Tips

ATS (Applicant Tracking System) Requirements

- **ATS compatibility:** Make your resume ATS compatible
- **Resources:**
 - [Zety ATS guide](#)
 - [Indeed ATS template](#)
- **Keyword highlighting:** Highlight major keywords in the resume
- **Date format:** Use MM/YYYY format for ATS systems

Grammar and Language

- **Grammar check:** Run proper Grammarly check
- **KGP Grammarly access:** [IIT KGP Grammarly link](#)
- **Bad English warning:** Bad English and grammar is a real turn-off... It's not just your tinder date but your interviewers also feel the same
- **Grammar tool note:** Even free version of Grammarly is very helpful
- **Casual note:** (To grammar nazis don't ruin my comment section.. this ain't my resume nor tin.....)
- **Spell check:** Verify spellings of all proper nouns, especially programming languages
- **Capitalization:** Follow proper capitalization for technical terms

Content Organization

- **XYZ rule:** Follow the XYZ rule for content writing ([YouTube guide](#))
 - **Project limit:** Write less than 6-7 points under one project (somewhat debatable but personal belief)
 - **Proper ordering:** Remove irrelevant content and order sections appropriately
 - **Tech focus:** For tech companies, avoid filling 1/4 of resume with PORs at the start
 - **One-page preference:** 1 Pager resume is highly advisable (tum kitne he mauchu kyu na ho 1 page me a jata hai) exception are always there
 - **Update note:** Will update with something else come up
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ERP System Specific Tips

Technical Precautions

- **Backup strategy:** Keep downloading the CV creation webpage as .html file periodically
- **Recovery method:** Use .html backup to copy-paste content back if CV goes blank or gets distorted
- **Loading patience:** Wait for the CV creation page to load completely before making changes
- **Browser indicator:** Ensure the 'processing/loading request' indicator in Chrome disappears before making changes
- **Photo update:** Shoot a picture in proper formal attire and update on ERP

Common ERP Issues

- **Blank CV problem:** CV may go blank or get distorted, especially near deadlines
 - **Text distortion:** Content formatting may get corrupted
 - **Loading issues:** Making changes before page fully loads causes problems
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Project and Achievement Presentation

Project Details

- **Affiliation mention:** Always mention project affiliation
- **Academic projects:** Include professor/professional names, department, and institution
- **Competition projects:** Mention the competition name
- **Personal projects:** Label as "Self-Project"
- **Links:** Add working/demonstrable links or GitHub repository links
- **README importance:** Ensure GitHub README explains the project well

Achievement Hierarchy

- **No redundancy:** Don't repeat lower-level achievements
- **Example:** If you won at Inter-IIT level, don't separately mention Intra-Hall gold for the same event

- **Impact writing:** Write "Won 1st Prize at FOO Competition as a member of BAR team" instead of "Member of BAR team that participated and won 1st prize in FOO Competition"

Language and Terminology

- **Avoid college-specific terms:** Don't use KGP-specific words/names/lingos
- **External perspective:** Remember recruiters are outsiders who won't understand internal terminology
- **Examples to avoid:** "Radhakrishnan Hall of Residence", "TSG"
- **Better alternatives:** Use "Gymkhana" instead of "TSG" if necessary
- **Correct terminology:** Use "alumni/alumnus/alumna" instead of "alums"
- **Alums clarification:** And then realise that words like alums are not real word (unless you want to talk about the substances). The actual words are alumni, alumnus or alumna

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Content Mistakes

- **Insufficient effort:** Not giving enough effort in CV making
- **Everything targeting:** Not deciding on specific companies/profiles and preparing for everything
- **Faking:** Never fake information in resume or interviews
- **Unexplainable points:** Unable to explain points written in your resume
- **POR overload:** Too many PORs, especially for tech profiles

Preparation Mistakes

- **No mock interviews:** Doing less or no mock interviews
- **IDE dependency:** Unable to write code without IDE
- **Missing interview experiences:** Not going through others' interview experiences
- **Ignoring details:** Missing out on tiny but important details
- **Unexplainable points:** Unable to explain points written in your resume (yeh toh hona he nai chaiye). Try to include only points you feel confident explaining
- **Closing note:** Yeh already kafi bada ho gaya some interview specific points in the next post and if you find this useful then tag your friends so that maximum people get benefits from this

Interview Preparation

Research and Practice

- **Interview experiences:** Study others' interview experiences thoroughly
- **Mock interviews:** Conduct sufficient mock interviews
- **Coding practice:** Practice writing code without IDE
- **Company research:** Research specific companies and profiles
- **Detail attention:** Pay attention to tiny details that matter

Resources

- Interview playlist: [YouTube playlist for interview experiences](#)
 - Power verbs: [185 Powerful Verbs guide](#)
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Pre-Review Checklist

Self-Review Process

1. **Ownership mindset:** Realize it's YOUR CV that will open or close doors for YOU
2. **Personal responsibility:** Don't transfer responsibility to reviewer
3. **Multiple reviews:** Go through CV multiple times before sending for review
4. **Error checking:** Look for spelling, formatting, grammar, and capitalization mistakes
5. **Guideline compliance:** Re-review each point against mentioned guidelines
6. **Thorough review:** Review multiple times until no more improvements are spotted
7. **Time management:** Start early, don't rush, give reviewers enough time

What's Acceptable vs Unacceptable

- **Acceptable mistakes:** Content or ordering mistakes (reviewers can help with these)
- **Unacceptable mistakes:** Spelling and grammatical errors (should be caught in self-review)
- **Rare exceptions:** 1-2 instances of missed errors are acceptable

Review Preparation

- **Quality before quantity:** Better to have less but more meaningful content
 - **Font size maintenance:** Increase to 10-11 if you have extra space after removing points
 - **Microspecialization:** Register for microspecialization if CG>7 and you need to fill space
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Dress Code for Interviews

Essential Items

- **Formal shirt:** Preferably white
- **Formal trousers:** Black
- **Tie:** Required
- **Formal shoes:** Black formal shoes
- **Blazer:** Optional, personal choice
- **Blazer note:** Ab iske upar blazer rakhna hai ya nahi that's up to you

Print Considerations

- **Physical copies:** Carry printed resumes for offline CDC interviews
 - **Legibility check:** Print and review for neatness and readability
 - **Font size rule:** Never use font size ≤ 9 (bold text can be 9 if regular text is 10)
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Additional Tips

Space Management

- **Right margin:** Avoid too much white space near right margin
- **Line completion:** Complete at least 75% of each line
- **Content balance:** Better to have less but meaningful content than filler content

Technical Considerations

- **Proper nouns:** Verify spellings and capitalization of programming languages and technical terms
- **Links and demos:** Include working links and GitHub repositories where possible
- **README quality:** Ensure project documentation is comprehensive

Final Reminders

- **Effort matters:** CV quality is a deciding factor in many companies
 - **Consistency:** Maintain consistent formatting throughout
 - **Impact focus:** Always highlight the impact of your contributions
 - **Numbers matter:** Recruiters love seeing quantifiable achievements
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Conclusion

Kindly follow these points before you send your CV for review so that the review process becomes easier for you and the reviewer doesn't lose their motivation.